working out who and what you can trust. If you are lucky, as you progress in your work you will have a young family to consider. You must rationalize their demands while never losing sight of the need to score enough runs or take enough wickets to keep the carousel turning.

Abu Dhabi, in April 2019, was the start of the transition to the final phase of my career. The stadium was deserted, apart from a small tour group escaping the English winter to watch Essex's low-key pre-season friendly with Somerset. When our bus pulled into the stadium forecourt, feral cats retreated out of the sun and watched intently from underneath parked cars.

Workmen painted the lobby and put up plasterboard partitions without energy or urgency. The dressing rooms were musty and carried veiled warnings to which we have become accustomed in an age of suspicion. 'Mobile Phones prohibited' read one sign. 'No internet access'. The number of a confidential whistleblowers' hotline was on a poster in the corridor outside.

Sitting behind clear plastic in the players' section of the stand, after scoring 50-odd, gave me the chance to weigh up the dynamics of a different dressing room. An England dressing room is a ruthless place, in which the preoccupation of highly motivated individuals is survival. A county team contains players in different phases of their careers, with contrasting motivations.

There's the eighteen-year-old kid, straight from the Academy. There's the twenty-two-year-old who has been around a bit, and has his eye on a county cap. There's the twenty-four-year-old who is privately fretting, thinking, 'This is my last chance.' There's the twenty-seven-year-old breakout player, desperate to be selected for England, and there's the thirty-seven-year-old who is still enjoying his cricket and wants to stick around for another couple of years.

I asked myself what my value would be to such a diverse group. I needed something other than the selfish pursuit of making big runs to quell the scary thought that there was a pointlessness to my presence. I got it when Maggs – Anthony McGrath, our second-year head coach – asked me to be a sounding board for anyone who needed the release of an alternative viewpoint.

He felt that people would pick up little things from me. I'm not the oracle. I've never pretended to know it all, but I suppose I'm not quite so self-contained as I once was. I designed a method to give me success and